Indians present “seemed … surprised” and in the latter case “deeply disturbed.”[89]

News reports from India indicated that Herter’s statement was greeted with “puzzled surprise,” but not the vitriol that might have been expected.[90] India needed all the friends it could get; moreover, the US had hastened to clarify Herter’s statement and reassure Indian officials. His office stated that he had been talking about the legal aspect of the border issue and unequivocally condemned the Chinese use of force to press its claims. The next day, in comments that were reported in the press, Herter assured the Indian chargé d’affaires that the US in no way condoned Chinese action; instead it found “wholly abhorrent” the “aggressive armed action” against India.[91] The embassy in Delhi furthermore ensured that a statement of US sympathy for the Indian position was published in major newspapers in India.[92]

The Indian foreign secretary told the US ambassador that India appreciated the clarification, but there should be no “ambiguity” about the border.[93] Internally, Indian officials assessed the possible reasons for the American position. The Indian embassy in Washington outlined a few: to avoid making the border issue a Cold War issue; the desire not to upset Taiwan; “genuine doubt”; general tradition of not commenting on the legality of claims; or the desire to give India maneuverability in case it had to give up some territory in the future. They were heartened by the quick criticism in the press of Herter’s “moral ambiguity about Peking’s aggressive thrust against India.”[94]

At a news conference, Eisenhower subsequently asserted that the exact points of the border dispute were not the major issue: “What is important and what is the issue is this: are nations going to settle their differences by negotiation, honest meeting, honest negotiation with each other, or are they going to move in with force and take that course in the settlement of these disputes?” Seeming to repudiate Herter’s comment, he asserted he was “very much on the side of the people that say we must do it by negotiation.”[95]

Eisenhower reiterated this support in December 1959 on his four-day trip to India, where he received a warm welcome from politicians, the press, and the public alike.[96] He expressed his sympathy to Nehru on the situation with China, stating that the question came down to whether to let “the matter